

Note: There are three Sections in the Assignment. You have to answer all questions in the Sections.

Assignment-I

Answer the following in about 500 words each.

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| 1. | Discuss the administration under the Guptas. | 20 |
| 2. | Write an essay on the growth of art and architecture between 300 CE and 1206 CE. | 20 |

Assignment-II

Answer the following in about 250 words each.

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| 3. | Discuss the history of conflicts amongst the powers of south India. | 10 |
| 4. | Describe the local administration under Chola. | 10 |
| 5. | What are the various views on the origin of Rajputs. | 10 |

Assignment-III

Answer the following in about 100 words each.

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|-----|--------------------------|---|
| 6. | Pallava-Pandya conflict | 6 |
| 7. | Emergence of Tantrism | 6 |
| 8. | Property rights of women | 6 |
| 9. | Growth of language | 6 |
| 10. | Shaktism | 6 |

Assignment Reference Material (July 2025 – Jan 2026)

BHIC-132

History of India From C.300 To 1206

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Assignment-I

Answer the following in about 500 words each.

Q1. Discuss the administration under the Guptas.

Ans. The Gupta kings did not interfere in the administration of those regions where the kings had accepted their suzerainty. However, this does not mean that the Guptas were ruling only through their feudatories. They had an elaborate administrative system which was in operation in areas which were directly controlled by them.

King

The king remained the central figure of administration. However, there was a considerable change in the character of monarchy. The Gupta monarchs adopted high sounding titles like:

- Paramabhattaraka,
- Parama-daivata,
- Chakravarti,
- Parameshvara etc.

Council of Ministers and Other Officials

The Gupta inscriptions are not very clear about the hierarchy of ministers. However, there is no doubt that the King used to take counsel of his ministers and issue written instructions to officials on all important matters.

The minister's office was perhaps hereditary. For example, the Udayagiri inscription of the time of Chandragupta-II informs us that Virasena Saba, the minister for war and peace, was holding this office by inheritance. Though the supreme judicial powers were vested in the King, he was assisted by the Mahadandanayaka (Chief Justice). In the provinces this work was entrusted to the Uparikas and in districts to the Vishayapatis. In villages, the headman and the village elders used to decide the petty cases. The Chinese traveller Fa-Hien states that capital punishment was not given at all.

Army

The Guptas must have had a big army organisation. At the time of war the King led his army but ordinarily there was a minister called Sandhi-Vigrahika (Minister in charge of peace and war) who was helped by a group of high officials. The official title Mahabaladhikrita occurs in many inscriptions. Officials like Pilupati (head of elephants), Ashvapati (head of horses), Narapati (head of foot soldiers) possibly worked under him. The army was paid in cash and its needs were well looked after by an officer-in-charge of stores called Ranabhandagarika. Amongst other duties this officer was to look after the supply of offensive and defensive weapons such as battle-axes, bows and arrows, spear pikes, swords, lances, javelins etc.

Revenue Administration

Land revenue was the main source of the state's income besides the fines. In Samudragupta's time we hear of an officer Gopasramin working as Akshapataladhikrita. His duty was to enter numerous matters in the accounts registers, recover royal dues from the sureties of servants, to check embezzlement and recover fines for loss due to neglect or fraud.

Another prominent high official was Pustapala (record-keeper). It was his duty to make enquiries before recording any transaction. The Gupta kings maintained a regular department for the proper survey and measurement of land as well as for the collection of land revenue. Kamandaka in the Nitisara suggests that a King should take special care of his treasury, for the life of the state depends solely on it.

Provinces, Districts and Villages

The whole empire was divided into Desas, or Rashtras, or Bhuktis. The inscriptions provide us with the names of certain Bhuktis. In Bengal we hear of PundravardharaBhukti which corresponded to north Bengal. Tira-bhukti corresponded to north Bihar. The Bhuktis were governed by Uparikas directly appointed by the King. In areas like western Malwa we find local rulers like Bandhuvarman ruling as subordinate to Kumaragupta-I but Parnadana was appointed a governor in Saurashtra by Skandagupta.

Q2. Write an essay on the growth of art and architecture between 300 CE and 1206 CE.

Ans. The period between 300 CE and 1206 CE marks one of the most flourishing phases in the history of Indian art and architecture. This era witnessed the rise of powerful dynasties such as the Guptas, Pallavas, Chalukyas, and Cholas, who, apart from expanding their political frontiers, laid strong foundations for India's architectural and artistic heritage. Religious developments, particularly the growing influence of Bhakti movements in Hinduism and continued patronage to Buddhism and Jainism, gave a strong impetus to temple-building activities, sculpture, painting, and metalwork during this time. Art was not merely decorative; it was an essential medium of spiritual expression and political assertion.

One of the most notable contributions of this period was in the field of temple architecture. The Gupta period marks the transition from rock-cut caves to structural temples made of brick and stone. The introduction of the garbhagriha (sanctum sanctorum) and the mandapa (pillared hall) became a defining feature of Indian temples. Temples like the Dashavatara temple at Deogarh, the Bhitargaon temple near Kanpur, and the Vishnu temple at Tigawa exhibit early forms of these architectural principles. The Panchayatana style—where the central shrine is surrounded by four subsidiary shrines—originated in this period and became a hallmark of temple design in later centuries.

The evolution of temple architecture continued into the post-Gupta and early medieval periods under regional powers. In the Deccan, the Chalukyas and Rashtrakutas built magnificent rock-cut cave temples at Badami, Aihole, and Ellora. In South India, the Pallavas pioneered structural stone temples, which were later perfected by the Cholas. The Brihadeshwara temple at Thanjavur, built under RajarajaChola I, is an exemplary symbol of Dravidian architectural grandeur with its towering vimana, precise layout, and rich sculptural details.

Alongside architecture, sculpture reached unprecedented heights in creativity, form, and symbolism. Gupta sculptors mastered the art of image-making with an emphasis on balance, grace, and spiritual serenity. The sculptures of deities like Vishnu, Shiva, and Durga from this period, particularly those at Udayagiri and Deogarh, are remarkable for their anatomical perfection and narrative richness. The image of Varaha rescuing the Earth from the ocean, found at Eran, is a powerful representation of cosmic protection and divine intervention. The Sarnath Buddha, carved in dharmachakrapravartana mudra, stands as a testament to the calm and spiritually charged aesthetic of Gupta art.

The Gupta period also saw the coexistence of various religious traditions. While Hinduism gained prominence, Buddhist and Jain artistic expressions thrived as well. Bronze and stone images of Buddha, Bodhisattvas, and Jain Tirthankaras from Mathura, Sarnath, Nalanda, and Udayagiri illustrate the religious harmony and pluralism of the time. These images were not only artistically refined but also reflected innovations like realistic drapery and expressive gestures. The metallurgical skill of the period is showcased in the Mehrauli Iron Pillar in Delhi, which remains rust-free even after centuries.

Painting during this period saw extraordinary development, particularly in the form of mural art. The Ajanta caves in Maharashtra are globally renowned for their stunning frescoes depicting scenes from the life of Buddha, Jataka tales, celestial beings, and glimpses of contemporary life. These murals are notable for their vibrant colors, sophisticated shading, naturalistic figures, and emotionally engaging compositions. The Bagh caves and Badami paintings also exhibit the high standards of Gupta-era art, blending religious devotion with refined artistic vision.

The artistic legacy of this era was not confined to religious centers alone. Urban settlements, trade guilds, and wealthy patrons also contributed to the growth of secular art. Artists depicted court scenes, royal processions, hunting expeditions, and scenes from domestic life, offering a window into the social and cultural fabric of the time.

Assignment-II

Answer the following in about 250 words each.

Q3. Discuss the history of conflicts amongst the powers of south India.

Ans. The political scenario of early medieval South India was dominated by recurring conflicts among regional powers, particularly between the Chalukyas of Badami and the Pallavas, and also between the Pallavas and the Pandyas. The Chalukyas, under Pulakesin-II, initially gained an upper hand by defeating Mahendravarman and raiding Pallava territories, but were later countered effectively by Narasimhavarman-I, who not only reversed the conquests but also captured Badami and possibly killed Pulakesin-II. Subsequent Chalukya rulers, notably Vikramaditya-I and Vikramaditya-II, retaliated with repeated incursions into Pallava domains. The Pandyas, too, posed a consistent threat, primarily due to their ambition to control the agriculturally rich Kaveri delta, as their own Vaigai valley lacked such fertility. Eventually, by the early 9th century CE, the Pandyas succeeded in securing this region.

Smaller principalities and chieftains, though individually insignificant, played crucial roles as allies or subordinates, participating in larger conflicts for plunder and territorial gains. Their collective involvement contributed to a fragmented political landscape in South India. The rugged geography and lack of centralized authority

meant that no single ruler could dominate the region completely between the 4th and 9th centuries. These conflicts sometimes led to new political formations, such as the rise of the Chalukyas of Lata in south Gujarat. The period also witnessed political interactions beyond the Indian subcontinent. The Pallavas supported exiled Lankan princes in gaining the throne of Anuradhapura and maintained naval influence in Southeast Asia, with possible links to Thailand. In Kerala, the Perumals ruled, with rulers like Cheraman Perumal noted for religious tolerance. Despite limited political data, the region's prosperity attracted repeated invasions from neighboring powers such as the Pandyas, Chalukyas, and Rashtrakutas.

Q4. Describe the local administration under Chola.

Ans. The local administration under the Cholas was a highly organized and elaborate system based on village and regional assemblies, with significant roles played by landholders and local elites. At the core of this structure were two primary units: the Ur and the Nadu. The Ur referred to the general assembly of non-Brahmana landholders in a village, while the Nadu was a territorial unit comprising several Urs, especially the agriculturally rich Vellanvagai villages. The Nattars, prominent landholders in the Nadu, were responsible for managing land grants, supervising irrigation, and overseeing temple donations and revenue collections. These assemblies had the authority to exempt taxes on donated lands and levy cesses for temple support.

Another key unit was the Brahmadeya, tax-free land grants given to Brahmanas. These settlements were managed by assemblies called Sabhas or Mahasabhas, which exercised judicial, fiscal, and administrative control over their regions. The Sabha appointed members based on qualifications like landholding, age, and knowledge. They managed temple properties, organized services, and maintained records.

In trading centers, the Nagaram was the urban counterpart comprising merchants and artisans. The merchant body, Nagarattar, had its own assembly and managed communal lands, tax collection, and support for temples, often functioning independently of the Nadu.

The Chola state integrated these local bodies into a centralized framework through a network of officials like Adhikaris, Senapatis, and revenue officers. Administrative units like Valanadus and Mandalam were created to streamline governance. While retaining local autonomy in practice, these assemblies functioned under royal oversight, ensuring an efficient and participatory system of administration that strengthened Chola control over a vast and diverse empire.

Q5. What are the various views on the origin of Rajputs.

Ans. The origin of the Rajputs is a subject of much debate and mystery, with various theories put forth by scholars. One prominent theory is the Agnikula myth, which

traces the origin of certain Rajput clans—like the Pratiharas, Solankis, Paramaras, and Chahamanas—to a sacrificial fire pit conducted by sage Vashistha at Mount Abu. This legend, however, is considered more symbolic than historical. Some scholars, such as Watson and Bhandarkar, linked these Rajputs to the Gurjara stock, though this view has been contested by others who argue that ‘Gurjara’ was both a region and a people, not necessarily a singular ethnic identity.

Another perspective suggests that the Rajputs emerged during a period of political fragmentation and social transformation following the decline of the Gupta Empire. During this time, feudal structures were consolidating, leading to the rise of warrior clans such as the Gurjaras, Guhilots, and Chahamanas in regions like Rajasthan and Gujarat. These groups eventually transitioned into ruling aristocracies, often asserting control over tribal lands and integrating them into a new agrarian order.

A more nuanced view comes from the processual theory, which sees the emergence of Rajputs not as a singular event but as a gradual socio-political process. This perspective emphasizes factors like territorial expansion, military strength, land grants to kin, fortification building, and strategic inter-clan marriages. Political dominance and the shift from feudatory to independent status further legitimized their claims to Kshatriya identity. This process also included the assimilation of tribal groups like the Meds and Hunas into Rajput status through upward mobility and ritual transformation. Thus, the formation of Rajput identity was dynamic, shaped by a combination of myth, socio-economic changes, political aspirations, and cultural integration over several centuries.

Assignment-III

Answer the following in about 100 words each.

Q6. Pallava-Pandya conflict

Ans. Conflicts and alliances were outcomes of the political ambition of the rulers to acquire more and more resources for the efficient functioning of their respective governments. The Chalukyas of Vatapi and the Pallavas of Kanchi were frequently at war with one another. The Pallava monarch Mahendravarman I had expanded the territory of the Pallava dynasty towards the north up to the river Krishna. The Vishnukundins became the neighbouring kingdom located to the north of the Pallavas. Pulakesin II defeated the Vishnukundins and the territory of the Vishnukundins became the part of Chalukyan dynasty. The Chalukyan king made his brother Kubja Vishnuvardhana the viceroy of this conquered territory. Later, Vishnuvardhana founded the eastern Chalukyan dynasty or the Chalukyan kingdom of Vengi. With the decline of Vishnukundins the Chalukyans became the neighbouring territory of the Pallavas to the north. Thus, the expansionist policies of Mahendravarman I and

Pulakesin II brought the two emperors together on a battlefield against each other. This began the constant conflicts between the two dynasties.

Q7. Emergence of Tantrism

Ans. The religious practices which originated in the most primitive fertility rites of the non-Aryan tribal circles later came to be known as Tantrism. It not only infiltrated into the other 'civilized' cults (Jainism, Buddhism, Shaivism, Vaishnavism etc.) but also emerged as a challenge and reaction to these cults, as all of them had developed vested interests and had become parts of the establishment by the early medieval period.

Tantrism penetrated Buddhist, Jaina and the Brahmana theology. Early Buddhism and Jainism tried their best to check the infiltration of these Tantric practices into their cults. In the earliest phase of their history Buddhism and Jainism launched a systematic campaign against the cult of image worship, rituals and sacrifices as destructive of all morals. They stressed on the purification of soul for the attainment of nirvana (salvation).

Q8. Property rights of women

Ans. Brahmanical law books recognized woman's right to inherit property in the absence male heirs. Women's right to property family indicates hold over property and reduced the possibilities of its seizure by state. Jimutavahana's Dayabhaga (12th century CE) and Vijnaneshvara's Mitakshara (11th century CE) also recognized the widow's right to inherit. But this was not practiced across the Indian sub-continent. Inscription of king Kumarapala of Gujarat dated to 1150 CE prescribes widow's right to inherit her husband's landed property. Another from Achchalpuram, Tamil Nadu, of Rajaditya Chola II talks about sabha or assembly's decision of a brahmadeya village to permit a widow to inherit the lands and other properties of her husband. The earlier rights of women in the form of stridhana expanded in the early medieval period. Early medieval commentaries and digests amplify the scope of sridhana. Mitakshara interprets it as property of any kind belonging to the women. But the definition is not uniform in all texts.

Q9. Growth of language

Ans. Sanskrit had suffered a serious setback since the time of Ashoka due to his widespread patronage to Buddhism. But now it got a fresh lease of life under the Guptas. They made it the official language of their court and liberally encouraged its use. All their inscriptions are written in Sanskrit. Ignored earlier under the influence of the Buddhist and Jaina traditions that wrote their scriptures and literary works in vernacular dialects like Pali, Prakrit and Ardhamagadhi, Sanskrit saw its revival under the Guptas. Due to the same, it became a widespread language in entire north India during this period. Even Buddhist scholars, particularly those of Mahayana

Buddhism, started composing their texts in Sanskrit. Similarly, many works of Jaina faith such as Nyaayavataara and Tatvaarthadhigama-sutra were authored in Sanskrit in place of Prakrit. This shows upper hand of Sanskrit over other languages that previously dominated the linguistic landscape of ancient India. It replaced them in scriptures, inscriptions and coins.

Q10. Shaktism

Ans. Shaktism did not begin by revolving around a deity. It originally began as the female principle – Shakti – in Brahmanism. As a principle, she was the consort of the three chief gods. Thus, she was Saraswati to Brahma, Lakshmi to Vishnu and Parvati or Durga to Shiva. It was only in the early centuries of the Common Era that Shakti became Devi and was worshipped as such in a cult dedicated solely to her worship. Since the worship of the female principle as mother goddess is believed to have been common among groups that were as yet untouched by Brahmanism, the Shakti cult developed a large following and further was central to Tantrism. The prime text of Shaktism is the Devi Bhagavata Purana.